LAST UPDATED: NOVEMBER 9, 2026

1969 GTO Judge Release Timeline from Pontiac Documents

Each entry quotes the document exactly. None of these documents names a VIN, dealer order number or dealer for a specific car.

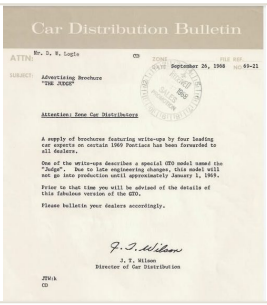
The Pontiac papers below are photographed copies held in Al Diaz's research files; where a copy came from is given in its entry when known. The May 8, 1969 Goad memo was first reported publicly by Mike Noun on the Performance Years forum in September 2015.

Sep 26, 1968

Car Distribution Bulletin 69-21, J. T. Wilson, Director of Car Distribution

"a special GTO model named the "Judge". Due to late engineering changes, this model will not go into production until approximately January 1, 1969."

Tier 2 · Documented fact


Car Distribution Bulletin

Mr. D. W. Logie — CD

ZONE — CLASS — DIV. NO.

SUBJECT: Advertising Brochure "THE JUDGE" — September 26, 1968 — 69-21

Attention: Zone Car Distributors

A supply of brochures featuring write-ups by four leading car experts on certain 1969 Pontiacs has been forwarded to all dealers.

One of the write-ups describes a special GTO model named the "Judge". Due to late engineering changes, this model will not go into production until approximately January 1, 1969.

Prior to that time you will be advised of the details of this fabulous version of the GTO.

Please bulletin your dealers accordingly.

J. T. Wilson
Director of Car Distribution

JTW:k
CD

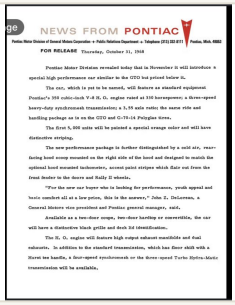
Oct 31, 1968

PMD Public Relations release

"The first 5,000 units will be painted a special orange color and will have distinctive striping." The car is yet to be named and has a 350 H.O. engine.

Tier 2 · Documented fact That it describes a planned car, not the Judge as announced:

Corroborated interpretation


NEWS FROM PONTIAC

Pontiac Motor Division — Public Relations Department

FOR RELEASE Thursday, October 31, 1968

Pontiac Motor Division revealed today that in November it will introduce a special high performance car similar to the GTO but priced below it.

The car, which is yet to be named, will feature as standard equipment Pontiac's 350 cubic-inch V-8 H. O. engine rated at 330 horsepower; a three-speed heavy-duty synchromesh transmission; a 3.55 axle ratio; the same ride and handling package as is on the GTO and G-70-14 Polyglas tires.

The first 5,000 units will be painted a special orange color and will have distinctive striping.

The new performance package is further distinguished by a mild air, rear-facing hood scoop mounted on the right side of the hood and designed to match the optional hood mounted tachometer, accent paint stripes which flair out from the front fenders to the doors and Rally II wheels.

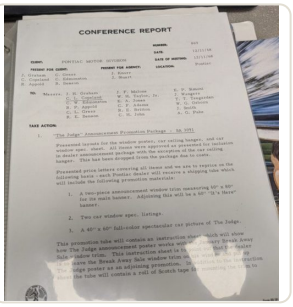
"For the new car buyer who is looking for performance, youth appeal and basic comfort all at a low price, this is the answer," John Z. DeLorean, a General Motors vice president and Pontiac general manager, said.

Available as a two-door coupe, two-door hardtop or convertible, the car will have a distinctive black grille and dash id identification.

The H. O. engine will feature high output exhaust manifolds and dual exhausts. In addition to the standard transmission, which has floor shift with a Hurst tee handle, a four-speed synchromesh or the three-speed Turbo Hydra-Matic transmission will be available.

Dec 11, 1968

Agency Conference Report No. 869, client Pontiac Motor Division

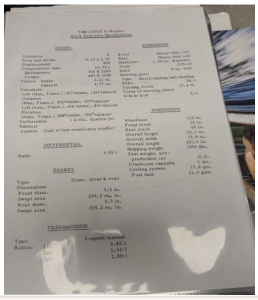

CONFERENCE REPORT

"'The Judge' Announcement Promotion Package - SA 3091"

Tier 4 Lead, auction listing photograph, original not examined Photograph from a Bring a Trailer auction listing, the seller's photo; credit belongs to the seller and Bring a Trailer. The listing is not yet identified. The report's content agrees with CDB 69-48 and with the surviving dealer tube kit shown in Smoke Signals, May 2019, page 16, Tier 3.

Undated

"THE JUDGE by Pontiac Quick Reference Specifications," filed with Conf. Report 869



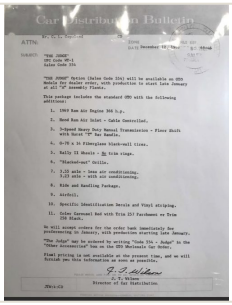
"Test weight, pre-production car N.A."

Tier 4 Lead, auction listing photograph, original not examined Photograph from a Bring a Trailer auction listing, the seller's photo; credit belongs to the seller and Bring a Trailer. The listing is not yet identified.

Date: Unresolved

Dec 12, 1968

Car Distribution Bulletin 69-48, J. T. Wilson

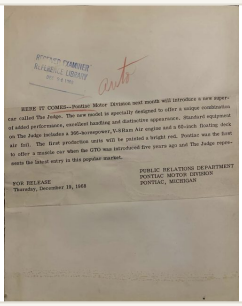

Car Distribution Bulletin

"production to start late January at all 'A' Assembly Plants"; "Color Carousel Red with Trim 257 Parchment or Trim 258 Black."

Tier 2 Documented fact

Dec 19, 1968

PMD release, Examiner reference library copy stamped Dec 24, 1968



HERE IT COMES—Pontiac Motor Division next month will introduce a new super-car called The Judge. The new model is specially designed to offer a unique combination of added performance, excellent handling and distinctive appearance. Standard equipment on The Judge includes a 366-horsepower, V-8 Ram Air engine and a 60-inch floating deck air foil. The first production units will be painted a bright red. Pontiac was the first to offer a muscle car when the GTO was introduced five years ago and The Judge represents the latest entry in this popular market.

FOR RELEASE
Thursday, December 19, 1968

PUBLIC RELATIONS DEPARTMENT
PONTIAC MOTOR DIVISION
PONTIAC, MICHIGAN

"The first production units will be painted a bright red."

Documented fact about the wording visible in the held copy. The page headed "HERE IT COMES" says Pontiac will introduce The Judge "next month" and lists a 366-horsepower V-8 Ram Air engine and a 60-inch floating deck air foil, as a paraphrase. The release line reads Thursday, December 19, 1968; the visible Examiner Reference Library receipt stamp reads Dec 24, 1968.

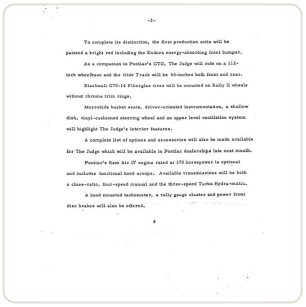
Copy provenance unresolved: this is the photographed copy held in Al Diaz's research files, not an authenticated original. Its chain of custody is unconfirmed, and where this copy came from is not yet documented. The existing Tier 2 listing identifies the purported factory-record copy, but its uncertain origin limits evidentiary weight under the policy. The image wording does not identify a VIN, DON, zone allocation, first nationwide car, or actual production start date. See copy-provenance note.

Undated

PMD release, page 2 only

“the first production units will be painted a bright red including the Endura energy-absorbing front bumper.”

Tier 2 · Documented fact · Date: Unresolved

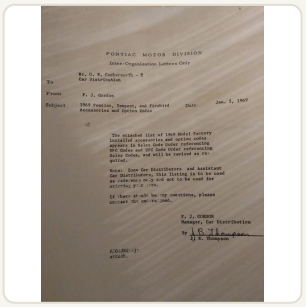


Jan 2, 1969

F. J. Gordon letter on accessories and option codes; page “Revisions to Oct. 29th Listing”

“554-WT1 NEW OPTION TEMPEST”

Tier 2 · Documented fact · That this page is the letter’s attachment rests on owner identification.



Jan 14, 1969

NEWS FROM PONTIAC price release

“$3,493.02 and $3,719.02 for the convertible.”

Tier 2 · Documented fact

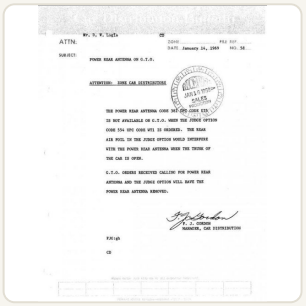


Jan 14, 1969

Car Distribution Bulletin No. 58, F. J. Gordon, rear antenna

“NOT AVAILABLE ON G.T.O. WHEN THE JUDGE OPTION CODE 554 UPC CODE WT1 IS ORDERED.”

Tier 2 · Documented fact



Late Jan 1969, printed Feb 2, 1969

Boston Herald Traveler, "Pontiac 'Judge' is Here," John Rooney

"Twenty five of the new Carousel Red, hardtop coupes were assigned to dealers to be driven to their dealerships."

Tier 3 **Documented fact** What the article reports; it names no VIN.


Pontiac 'Judge' is Here

Feb 17, 1969

The Pontiac Press, Pontiac, Mich., page C-6: retail ad

"The Judge.. Now presiding at Pontiac Retail Store, 65 University Drive and E. Wide Track." The ad lists a 366-hp 400 Ram Air V-8, floor-mounted 3-speed, 60-inch spoiler, mag-type wheels and "blue-red-yellow striping."

Tier 3 **Documented fact** Period newspaper.

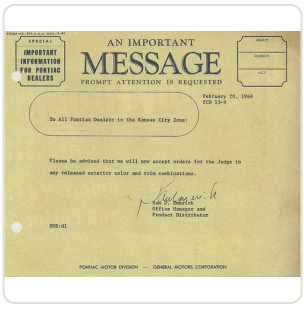


Feb 20, 1969

Kansas City Zone dealer message ZCD 13-9, Sam D. Emerick

"we will now accept orders for the Judge in any released exterior color and trim combinations."

Tier 2 **Documented fact**

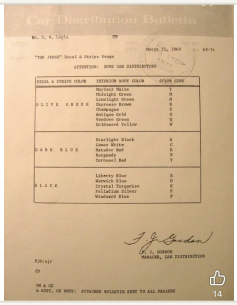


Mar 31, 1969

Car Distribution Bulletin 69-74, F. J. Gordon

"'THE JUDGE' Decal & Stripe Usage"

Tier 2 **Documented fact**


Car Distribution Bulletin

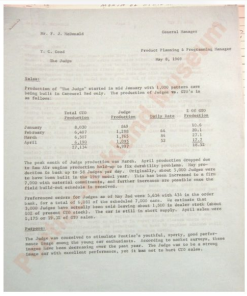
May 8, 1969

Memo, T. C. Goad to F. J. McDonald, “The Judge,” page 1

“started in mid January with 1,000 pattern cars being built in Carousel Red only”

Tier 2 Documented fact

First reported publicly by Mike Noun on the Performance Years forum, Sep 21, 2015.

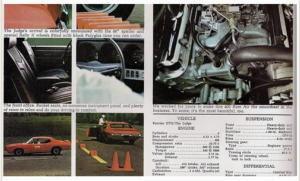


Undated, 1969 model year

Judge sales brochure spread

Lists the 400 Ram Air engine at 366 horsepower at 5100 rpm, as a paraphrase.

Tier 2 Documented fact Date: Unresolved



Not on file: page 1 of the undated release; page 2 of the Goad memo.